

In what follows, I'll set preference hedonism to the side, and focus on the success theory. Most of the issues that will come up would also apply to preference hedonism — so if you prefer that view, you can substitute accordingly.

Here's a problem for the view that desires play the central role which
the success theory gives to them:

Consider this example. Knowing that you accept a Summative theory, I tell you that I am about to make your life go better. I shall inject you with an addictive drug. From now on, you will wake each morning with an extremely strong desire to have another injection of this drug. Having this desire will be in itself neither pleasant nor painful, but if the desire is not fulfilled within an hour it will then become very painful. This is no cause for concern, since I shall give you ample supplies of this drug. Every morning, you will be able at once to fulfil this desire. The injection, and its after-effects, would also be neither pleasant nor painful. You will spend the rest of your days as you do now.

Would it make your life go better to be injected with the addictive
drug?

Intuitively, no. You will always have to remember to have ample supplies of the drug around, and will have to give yourself an injection every morning. None of these are things that you want to do.

On the other hand, if you take the drug, you will have a whole new group of extremely strong desires: the desire to take the drug each morning of your life. And each of these extremely strong desires will be satisfied. But according to the success theory, having your desires — especially your very strong desires — satisfied if what makes your life go well. So according to the success theory, taking the drug does make your life go (much) better.

This is of course a made up case. But there are real life cases which are
relevantly like it.

Violet is a softball player. Every time she comes to the plate, she wants very badly to get a hit. But softball is hard, and even the best players don't get hits most of the time. So, knowing that her life goes worse when her strongly held desires about her life are not met, Violet decides to get rid of this desire. Now when she comes to the plate, does not desire to get a hit. She gets hits less often now; but her life is better, since now her desires are not frustrated.

But even after we introduce this distinction between summative and global theories, one might think that a problem somewhat like the one posed by the case of Violet remains. This is brought out by the example of the grass-counter:

Consider the man that Rawls imagined who wants to spend his life counting the numbers of blades of grass in different lawns. Suppose that this man knows that he could achieve great progress if instead he worked in some especially useful part of Applied Mathematics. Though he could achieve such significant results, he prefers to go on counting blades of grass. On the Success Theory, if we allow this theory to cover all imaginable cases, it could be better for this person if he counted his blades of grass rather than achieving great and useful mathematical results.

Here the desire to spend his life counting blades of grass is a global desire. So even the global success theory has to say that the man has a better life counting blades of grass than he would have achieving great and useful things in mathematics.

One can have two different kinds of reactions to this case.

First, one might regard this result as unproblematic. If this is what the man wants to spend his life doing, then his best life genuinely is spent counting blades of grass.

On the other hand, one might regard this as a waste of a life. Counting blades of grass is pointless; and a life spent doing pointless things can't be a good life.

One way to bring out the second response is to imagine that the grass-counter is someone you love — perhaps a child. Suppose that you want them to have the best life possible, and that you know that they desire life as a grass-counter. Wouldn't you still hope that they moved on from grass-counting at some point?

If you think this, then this would be a reason to abandon the success
theory in favor of what Parfit calls an **objective list theory**.

An objective list theory says that a good life is one which contains certain features — the ones on the objective list of good-making features. What gets on the list is not determined by what you want — it is something fixed independently of your desires.

The objective list theorist can say that, despite his global desires, the grass-counter would have lived a better life by spending his time on other pursuits.

The natural question for the objective list theorist is: what determines
what gets on the objective list?

There are different answers to this question. The one we will explore goes back to Aristotle.

Let's forget about human lives for a second, and think about the lives of
non-human animals. Consider the following two beasts:





We can ask, of either animal, what it would take for their life to go best.

Do we get the same answer in the two cases?

It is natural to think that we do not. Lions are different kinds of things than dogs, and so the best kind of life for a lion will be very different than the best kind of life for a dog. In each case it depends on the nature of lions, and the nature of dogs.

Humans are different than both lions and dogs. So, Aristotle thought, to figure out what the best human life is, we have to ask: what is part of human nature?

When we ask this question, a number of plausible answers suggest themselves:

Humans have bodies (of certain distinctive kinds).

Humans are social animals, who live with other humans.

Humans are rational animals, who try to get knowledge about what the world is like.

Humans are creative animals, who make art and music.

Humans are strategic animals, who plan for the future.

According to a perfectionist view, the best human life is the one which most perfects these aspects of human nature. The reason why these aspects matter is because they are part of what it is to be human — just as perfection in the hunting of gazelles matters for lions but not my dog, because this kind of hunting is in the nature of lions but not of my dog.

Does this mean that the best life for me is the same as the best life for you,
even though we are different in any number of ways?

No. One of the ways in which people differ is in their capacity for perfection in various dimensions. You may have the capacity for great artistic creativity; I do not. This might mean that your greatest overall perfection would be achieved by devoting yourself to music, whereas mine would not be.

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This leaves lots of important questions unanswered. Sometimes trying to perfect one aspect of my nature conflicts with trying to perfect others. If I focused solely on trying to produce the best philosophy that I can, my physical well being would suffer and I would ignore the social aspect of my nature. Different perfectionists have different views about how these trade-offs should be managed.

To each such aspect corresponds (at least) one virtue. For example, virtues to do with our social nature might include justice, generosity, patience, and kindness.

substitute accordingly.

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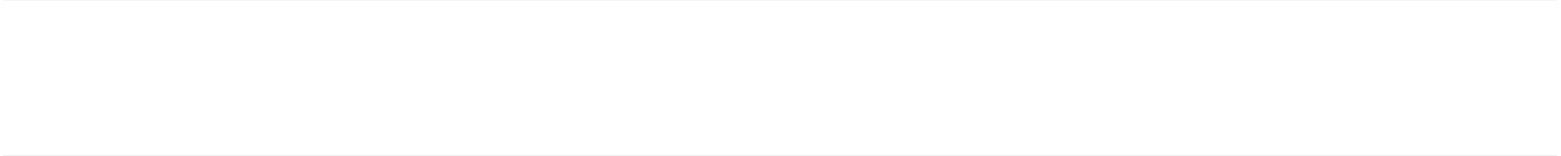
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not. This might mean that you're not achieving what you want, but it could also mean that you're not trying hard enough. It's important to understand the context of the word "not" and how it's being used. In this case, it seems to be a simple statement of fact, but it could also be a warning or a challenge. The word "not" is a powerful tool in communication, and it's important to use it wisely.

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Indeed, these unanswered questions are the source of the central

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objections to virtue theory, which is that the theory does not seem to tell us

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